

On the Trade route through Nathula: Mr Chamling believes the trade route through the Nathula Pass which reopened on July 6, 2006 after 44 years of gap should be developed into a full-fledged one. He feels, "Though the volume of trade through the Nathula pass has been low and has not met expectations, it has the potential to become a profitable route."

"Resumption of the historic trade route through Nathu La is going to help business in Sikkim in no small measure. As you are aware, the trade route through Nathu La is the shortest route between India and China and Sikkim, through which this trade route passes, will derive multiple benefits as it will give a huge boost to the tourism industry and become a hub of commercial activities and the focal point of business transactions. Infrastructure will be created in Sikkim to facilitate trade activities, which in turn will generate more employment and economic prosperity for the people of Sikkim."

On the issues of Rural Development: Speaking about his state's performance, Mr Chamling said Sikkim was the only state that has allocated 70 percent of its budget for rural development. This has greatly improved rural habitation both in terms of rural connectivity, increased awareness on education and health, poverty alleviation and overall progress in the social sector well-being.

On Empowerment of people in the Model State: Mr Chamling has said, "Empowerment of people is the core content of our political philosophy. If individuals are happy, communities are contented and institutions are sound, we believe that the country will be in a fast forward progress mode. Social mobilization in the nation building process then will be easier and smoother. We are doing exactly this in Sikkim."

On issues of women empowerment: The government of Sikkim to ensure the girl child's financial security and empowerment. To ensure the girl child's financial security, the government deposits Rs 5000 per annum for as soon as she turns 13. When she reaches college, the girl gets the interest the money has earned so far. Then at 23, when she enters the marriageable age, she gets an installment from the same investment. Finally, at 50, she gets the full and final amount. But there is a clause here — she should have only two children! This helps ensure population control. The Prerna Yojana gives the girl toppers of every school an amount ranging from Rs 1000 to Rs 3000 per month.

"Look at our gender development index which is perhaps the highest in the country. Besides the well researched and jealously maintained traditional liberal social practices, Sikkim is the only State in the country which has offered plethora of privileges for the welfare of the women including the 40 percent affirmative share at all levels of rural governance"

"I feel proud to see the way women are contributing to my governance and the equal rights they share with the men."

The government's Universal Financial Project was introduced to stress on fiscal empowerment and discipline among our common people. Under this scheme, at least one member, preferably a female, will open a no frills Bank Account through the Business Correspondent Route of any nationalised or good private bank.

The Government will deposit certain amount of money in the Bank and any payment admissible for the individual under various scheme could be directly credited in the bank account. This project will also have insurance cover of maximum of 6

members in unforeseen crisis and perils like life, health and accident. Needless to say that this scheme will end the role of middlemen who exploit one and all.

"We have effectively introduced the post-modern concept of affirmative share for our women so that they are fully empowered — socially, economically and politically," he said.

SIKKIM 1st in the Country

- To allocate 70 % of plan allocation for rural development
- To allocate 20 percent annual budget to Education sector
- To record highest allocation of 31.3 percent budget to social sector
- To host richest communities of Bhutia and Lepcha under ST category in the country with per capita asset value of Rs. 71,700 as against national average of the STs of Rs. 30,000 (NSS data)
- To realize highest per capita happiness index among its citizens
- To reserve 40 % seats to women under PRI, 30% in govt. job and women reservation in police recruitment
- To legally provide for equal Inheritance Rights to female members to parental properties
- To successfully address environmental issues through drastic policy measures; over 2 percent increase in forest cover over a decade
- To be ranked first on best in conserving natural resources.
- To institute Glacier & Climate Change Commission
- To become first Nirmal Rajya for 100 percent sanitation coverage
- To provide free Hepatitis B vaccination to children between age group of 0 -5 years